

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · EPISODE 3

Feudal Japan

Courts, Shoguns and the Quiet Arts

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A BEDTIME COMPANION

Two maps, a timeline from Heian-kyō to the Meiji Restoration, the people and places you'll meet in the episode, and a short list of trusted books, museums and podcasts, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

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The islands of the warriors

Let's begin with the islands, the mountains and the inland sea.



Places from the episode plotted at their real locations on a modern base map (Natural Earth). Coastlines are modern.

AT A GLANCE

- For centuries Japan had two centres of power
- The emperor's court in Kyoto
- Warrior governments that ruled from Kamakura, from Kyoto again under the Ashikaga, and at last from Edo

Places you'll visit in the episode

Ten places from the episode, from Kyoto to Dejima.

Kyoto · Heian-kyō, the capital founded in 794, home of the imperial court for over a thousand years.

Kamakura · Seat of Minamoto no Yoritomo's warrior government, from the 1180s to 1333.

Dan-no-ura · The sea battle of 1185 that ended the Genpei War.

Hakata Bay · Where the Mongol fleets landed in 1274 and 1281.

Golden Pavilion · Ashikaga Yoshimitsu's villa in the northern hills of Kyoto.

Tanegashima · The island where, by convention in 1543, Portuguese traders brought firearms.

Azuchi · Oda Nobunaga's castle above Lake Biwa.

Sekigahara · The battle of 1600 that opened the way for Tokugawa Ieyasu.

Edo · The Tokugawa capital, today's Tokyo, where lords came and went under sankin-kōtai.

Dejima · The small artificial island at Nagasaki where Dutch traders were kept.

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SEVEN CENTURIES, SLOWLY

A timeline, 794 to 1868

Seven centuries of courts and shoguns, one quiet step at a time.

AT A GLANCE

794	1192	1600 · 1603	1868
Heian-kyō	Yoritomo, shogun	Sekigahara; Ieyasu	Meiji Restoration

Historians still debate when "feudal Japan" began and ended; this timeline follows the episode, from the Heian court to the Meiji Restoration.

794	The court moves to a new capital, Heian-kyō, today's Kyoto.
c. 1000	Murasaki Shikibu and Sei Shōnagon write at the Heian court.
1180–1185	The Genpei War; the Taira are defeated at Dan-no-ura, and the child emperor Antoku is lost at sea.
1192	Minamoto no Yoritomo receives the title of shogun.
1199	Yoritomo dies; the Hōjō rule as regents.
1232	The Goseibai Shikimoku, a warrior law code, is issued.
1274 · 1281	Two Mongol invasions; storms wreck the fleets.
1333	Kamakura falls; Go-Daigo's Kenmu Restoration begins.
1336–1392	Northern and Southern Courts rival each other.
1397	Ashikaga Yoshimitsu begins his villa, the Golden Pavilion.
1467–1477	The Ōnin War opens the age of warring states.

SEVEN CENTURIES, SLOWLY

A timeline, 794 to 1868

The story goes on from here, slowly.



1543 · 1549	Firearms reach Tanegashima; Francis Xavier arrives.
1560	Oda Nobunaga wins at Okehazama.
1573 · 1582	The Ashikaga shogunate ends; Nobunaga dies at Honnō-ji.
1590s	Toyotomi Hideyoshi unifies Japan and invades Korea; he dies in 1598.
1600 · 1603	Sekigahara; Tokugawa Ieyasu becomes shogun.
1615	The fall of Osaka Castle.
1637–1638	The Shimabara rebellion.
Late 1600s	Bashō's journeys; woodblock prints, kabuki and puppet theatre flourish.
1853	Commodore Perry's ships arrive.
1868	The Meiji Restoration ends the rule of the shoguns.

Japan and its neighbours

Now let's step back and look at Japan's neighbours across the sea.



Approximate extent of Kamakura Japan and of the Mongol Yuan realm around 1279, between the two invasions, simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset; borders are approximate. Later links are shown too: Ming trade through Ningbo, Portuguese Macau, Hideyoshi's invasions of Korea in the 1590s.

People you'll meet

The writers, warriors and artists you'll meet along the way.

Murasaki Shikibu · Court lady who wrote The Tale of Genji, around 1000.

Sei Shōnagon · Court lady whose Pillow Book lists the pleasures of Heian life.

Minamoto no Yoritomo · Founder of the Kamakura shogunate; shogun from 1192.

Go-Daigo · Emperor who overthrew Kamakura and tried to rule in his own name.

Ashikaga Takauji · Warrior who broke with Go-Daigo and founded the Ashikaga shogunate.

Ashikaga Yoshimitsu · Shogun who built the Golden Pavilion and traded with Ming China.

People you'll meet

Zeami · With his father Kan'ami, shaped the Noh theatre.

Oda Nobunaga · First of the three unifiers; died at Honnō-ji in 1582.

Toyotomi Hideyoshi · Unified Japan, ordered the sword hunts and invaded Korea.

Tokugawa Ieyasu · Victor of Sekigahara and founder of the Tokugawa peace.

Sen no Rikyū · Tea master of wabi-cha, ordered to take his own life in 1591.

Matsuo Bashō · Poet of the late 1600s, author of The Narrow Road to the Deep North.

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WHILE YOU LISTEN

Things to spot, legend and history

A few things to listen for, and a note on legend and history.

THINGS TO SPOT IN THE EPISODE

- Murasaki Shikibu and Sei Shōnagon writing at the Heian court
- The storms that wrecked the Mongol fleets
- Ashikaga Yoshimitsu's Golden Pavilion
- Oda Nobunaga's castle above Lake Biwa
- Commodore Perry's ships arriving in 1853

LEGEND OR HISTORY?

The storms that wrecked the Mongol fleets were real, but the idea of a "divine wind" protecting Japan grew stronger in later centuries. The date 1543 for the first firearms is conventional, and "closed country" (sakoku) is partly misleading: trade went on through Nagasaki, Korea, the Ryukyus and the north. The episode keeps these apart from what the sources show.





Artistic impressions of Azuchi Castle above Lake Biwa and of a small tea room, made for the episode. They are not historical records.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Books to read

If you'd like to wander a little further, here are some trusted places to start.

A History of Japan ↗, Conrad Totman (Blackwell, 2nd ed., 2005).

Samurai: The World of the Warrior ↗, Stephen Turnbull (Osprey, 2003).

Hideyoshi ↗, Mary Elizabeth Berry (Harvard University Press, 1989).

The Tale of Genji ↗, Murasaki Shikibu, trans. Royall Tyler (Penguin Classics, 2003).

The Pillow Book ↗, Sei Shōnagon, trans. Meredith McKinney (Penguin Classics, 2006).

The Narrow Road to the Deep North and Other Travel Sketches ↗, Bashō, trans. Nobuyuki Yuasa (Penguin Classics).

📚 FIND THESE BOOKS — TAP HERE →

Full reading list ↗

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Museums, places and podcasts

Museums & places

Tokyo National Museum: armour, scrolls, swords and tea wares.

Kyoto National Museum: the art of the old capital.

Royal Ontario Museum, Toronto: the Prince Takamado Gallery of Japan.

In Japan: the Golden Pavilion (Kinkaku-ji) in Kyoto and the Great Buddha of Kamakura.

Podcasts

The History of Japan Podcast, Isaac Meyer: from prehistory to the present, since 2013.

A BEDTIME QUESTION

Would you rather spend an evening at the Heian court in Kyoto, or in a small tea room?

"The islands remain, breathing with the tide. The mountains hold their mist. And you are free to drift on that mist as far as sleep will take you."

LISTEN TO THE FULL EPISODE, AND FIND THE NEXT ONE

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Dreaming Ages History · Narration is AI-generated text-to-speech; illustrations are AI-generated artistic impressions. Facts follow the episode script and its sources. Maps drawn from real coordinates: Natural Earth; historical borders simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset (A. Ourednik). Free for personal use. Sleep well. 🌙